

Academic Writing

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Unit 1 Background to Writing

Most Business schools assess students mainly through written assignments. These include coursework, which may take weeks to write, and exam answers, which often have to be written in an hour or less. This unit deals with:

- The names of different writing tasks
- The format of long and short written texts
- The structure of sentences and paragraphs

A. The Purpose of Academic Writing

The reasons for writing include:

- To answer a question the writer has been given or chosen
- To report a piece of research the writer has conducted
- To synthesize research done by others on a topic
- To publish in a Journal article, proceeding, competition, etc. Anything else?

The writing process

- Working alone or in a group, list your ideas below:

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B. Common types of academic writing

- Match the term on the left to the definitions on the right

Notes	A piece of research, either individual or group work, with the topic chosen by the student(s).
Report	The longest piece of writing normally done by a student (20,000+ words) often for a higher degree, on a topic chosen by the student.
Project	A written record of the main points of a text or lecture, for a student's personal use.
Essay	A general term for any academic essay, report or article.
Dissertation/Thesis	A study of something that has happened (e.g. a survey a student has conducted)
Paper	The most common type of written work, with the title given by the teacher, normally 1,000 – 5,000 words.

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C. The format of long and short writing tasks

- **Short essays** (including exam answers) generally have this pattern:

- Introduction
- Main Body
- Conclusion

- **Longer essays** may include:

- Introduction
- Main Body
- Literary Review
- Case Study
- Discussion

References

Conclusion

Appendices

- **Dissertation and Journal articles** may have:

- Abstract
- List of contents
- List of Tables
- Introduction
- Main Body

Literature review

Case Study

Findings

Discussion

- Conclusion
- Acknowledgements
- References
- Appendices

Task 1: Find the words in the lists above that match the following definitions:

(a) A short summary of 100-200 words that explains the paper's purpose and main findings.

.....
.....

(b) A list of all the sources the writer has mentioned in the text.

.....
.....

(c) A section, at the end, where additional information is included.

.....
.....

(d) A short section where people who have helped the writer are thanked

.....
.....

(e) Part of the main body in which the views of other writers on the topic are discussed.

.....

Task 1: Find the words in the lists above that match the following definitions:

(a) A short summary of 100-200 words that explains the paper's purpose and main findings.

....**Abstract**.....
.....

(b) A list of all the sources the writer has mentioned in the text.

.....**References**.....
.....

(c) A section, at the end, where additional information is included.

.....**Appendix**.....
.....

(d) A short section where people who have helped the writer are thanked

.....**Acknowledgements**.....
.....

(e) Part of the main body in which the views of other writers on the topic are discussed.

.....**Literature**

D. The format of Academic Writing

- There is considerable variation in the format of academic writing required by different business schools and departments. But some general features apply to most formats:

Look at POLBAN's guideline in writing the student's final Project and internship report.

Task 2: Read the text below and Identify the features underlined, using the words in the box

Sentence	Heading	Subtitle	Paragraph	Title	Phrase
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- (a) The Effectiveness of Microcredit
- (b) An evaluation of programs in India and the Philippines
- (c) Introduction
- (d) In the last ten years, considerable claims have been made about the value of microcredit (also known as microfinance), the provision of unsecured small loans to the poor in developing countries. (e) But it has proved surprisingly difficult to accurately measure the effectiveness of these loans, without interference from other non-commercial factors.
- (f) Two recent studies have attempted to compare the effects on randomly chosen groups of people with access to microcredit, compared to those without. The first (Banerjee, et al., 2009), based at Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT). Looked at slum dwellers in the city of Hyderabad in India, while the second (Karlan and Zinman, 2009) compared borrowers and non-borrowers in the Philippines. Overall, neither study found evidence that microcredit had any effect in reducing poverty, although it may have some other positive aspects such as reducing the consumption of alcohol or tobacco.
- | | | | | | |
|-----------|--------------|-------------|------------|--------------|---------------|
| (a) Title | (b) Subtitle | (c) Heading | (d) Phrase | (e) Sentence | (f) Paragraph |
|-----------|--------------|-------------|------------|--------------|---------------|

E. Other Common text features

- (a) **Reference** to source: *The first (Banerjee et al., 2009) looked at slum dwellers*
- (b) The use of **abbreviation** to save space: *Massachusetts institute of Technology (MIT)*
- (c) **Italics** used to show words from other languages: *Banerjee et al.* (and others)
- (d) **Brackets** used to give subsidiary information or to clarify a point: *(also known as microfinance)*
- (e) **Numbering systems** (1.1., 1.2) are often used in writing reports, less so in essays.

F. Simple and Longer Sentences

- Study the table below:

Dragon motors – vehicle production 2009- 2013

2009	2010	2011	2012	2013
135,470	156,935	154,820	159,550	123,075

All sentences contain verbs:

In 2009, the company produced over 135,000 vehicles.

Between 2009 and 2010, vehicle production increased by 20%.

Simple sentences (above) are easier to write and read, but longer sentences are also needed in academic writing.

Longer Sentences...

Sentences containing two or more clauses use **conjunctions, relative pronouns, or punctuation** to link the clauses:

*In 2009, Dragon Motors produced over 135,000 vehicles **but** the following year production increased by 20 per cent. (conjunction)*

*In 2011, the company built 164,820 vehicles, **which** was the peak of production. (relative pronoun)*

Nearly 160,000 vehicles were produced in 2012; by 2013, this had fallen to 123,000. (punctuation)

Task 3: Now, write two simple and two longer sentences by using data from the table:

2009	2010	2011	2012	2013
135,470	156,935	154,820	159,550	123,075

(a) _____

(b) _____

(c) _____

(d) _____

G. Writing in Paragraphs

- Starter: Discuss the following questions:
 1. What is a paragraph?
 2. Why are texts divided into paragraphs?
 3. How long are paragraphs?
 4. Do paragraphs have a standard structure?
 5. How to start a writing a good paragraph?

Read the text below and divide it into a suitable number of paragraphs

INVESTMENT STRATEGIES

Most people want to invest for the future, to cover unexpected financial difficulties and provide security. Different people, **however**, tend to have different requirements, so that a 25-year-old just leaving university would be investing for long-term capital growth, **whereas** a 60-year-old who had just retired would probably invest for income. **Despite** these differences, certain principles apply in most cases. The first issue to consider is risk. In general, the greater the degree of risk, the higher the return. Shares, for example, which can quickly rise or fall in value, typically have a higher yield than bonds, **which** offer greater stability. **Therefore**, all investors must decide how much risk is appropriate in their particular situation. Diversification must also be considered in an investment strategy. Wise investors usually seek to spread their investments across a variety of geographical and business sectors. As accurate predictions of the future are almost impossible, it is best to have as many options as possible. A further consideration is investor involvement. Some investors opt for a high degree of involvement **and** want to buy and sell regularly, constantly watching the markets. **But** personal involvement can be time-consuming and worrying, and many prefer to leave the management of their portfolios to professional fund managers.

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